RANI OF DRAMA

Ekta Kapoor, *48*
Joint Managing Director, Balaji Telefilms

MOST PEOPLE CELEBRATE after winning a big international award. Ekta Kapoor gets back to work. Recently bestowed with the International Emmy Directorate Award for "her remarkable career and influence on the television industry", Kapoor didn't want the accolade to seem like she's at the fag end of her career. "My job is my oxygen, I would hate that," she says. "I want to reboot, realign to this industry of young people and learn from them. I don't want to look back...I really feel Chapter III is beginning for me."

Chapter I began at the age of 17 when Ekta, with funding from her father, the actor Jeetendra, started the then Dolphin Telefilms with her mother, Shobha. The initial days were tough. Five pilots she created went unsold. With the last remaining money, she made the sitcom *Hum Paanch* (1995). Zee TV would pick it up. Ekta gradually learnt the art of negotiation and grew "a thick skin". Today, she is regarded as the miracle hit-maker of Indian TV, producing long-running soaps like *Kyunki... Saas Bhi Kabhi Bahu Thi, Kahaani Ghar Ghar Ki, Kasauti Zindagi Kay,* to name a few.

Drama, for Kapoor, stems from the "extreme level of sacrifice people expect women to make". Her female protagonists have been part of the zeitgeist at different times for different reasons. *Kyunki*'s Tulsi would kill her son for marital rape; *Bade Achhe*'s Priya would create ripples in households for featuring an intimate episode while the women of *Veere Di Wedding* would talk about sex with one even masturbating. With her films (*Lipstick Under My Burkha, Dolly Kitty aur Chamakte Sitaare*) and web series on AltBalaji, she also began to have heroines who are messy. "Sexually liberal and emotionally assertive women are still judged, it's a war we need to win constantly," says Ekta.

"To be scared of failure is to be sure of failure," is a dictum she lives by. It's also why even after 150-plus shows and 45-plus films, she continues to be relevant. The legend around her continues to grow—the meetings at odd hours, the midnight strolls, they all contribute to it. "I did my best work at night. The moment I went corporate and began to do early mornings, I was making crap," says Ektaa laughing. "You have to accept your DNA and know the beast you are and live it out." And this beast is still hungry. ■

– Suhani Singh

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MILES TO GO...

"The journey for every woman is from conformity to individuality. Hopefully, you get to embark on it young, not at an age when you have regrets"

↘ **THE INSPIRATION** **My mother Shobha Kapoor. She restarted her life at 48 when she began working with me from my dad's garage and she is still coming in to work at 75**

↘ **SWITCHING OFF** **Watching content, eating good food, being with my son, hanging out with friends**

Photographs by BANDEEP SINGH